

SauceLab Vending

2,000 custom sauce combos from one machine — the snack that markets itself.

What It Is

SauceLab is a custom-sauce vending machine (pioneered by Heinz) that lets customers mix from 2,000+ flavor combinations on a touchscreen. You place a cup under the nozzle, pick your blend, and the machine instantly dispenses a one-of-a-kind sauce. The novelty is the product: people love inventing weird combos, filming the dispense, and posting it — which turns the machine itself into a free marketing engine.

How It Makes Money

You own the machine and charge ~\$2 per custom cup to foot traffic in entertainment and food venues. Buyers are families, teens, and snackers chasing a fun, shareable experience — plus food-court operators who want an attraction that pulls crowds. Revenue is cups x price minus sauce-concentrate cost. Secondary income: branded sponsorship (a sauce brand pays to be featured) and placing multiple machines across venues.

Startup Costs

- **The machine (Alibaba / China sourcing):** Custom liquid/sauce dispensing vending machines from Guangdong suppliers run **\$5,500–\$12,000 per unit** FOB. Search "custom sauce dispenser vending machine" or "liquid condiment dispensing machine" — MOQ usually 1.
- **Sea freight + import duty to US:** **\$700–\$1,400** per machine.
- **Customs, broker, install:** **\$300–\$600**.
- **Initial inventory** (sauce concentrate bags, base, cups, lids): **\$400–\$800**.
- **Location placement rent:** **\$400–\$1,500/month** (theme parks and stadiums command more).
- **Permits, LLC, insurance, food-safety compliance:** **\$600–\$1,800**.
- **Realistic all-in to launch one machine:** **\$8,000–\$16,000**.

The Numbers

- Concentrate + cup + lid cost per serving: **~\$0.30**
- Sell price: **\$2.00**
- Card processing + electricity per cup: **~\$0.15**
- **Profit per cup: ~\$1.55**
- At a realistic **120 cups/day** (not the hype 200): $120 \times \$1.55 =$ **\$186/day**, or **~\$5,580/month** per machine before rent.
- Subtract location rent (\$700) and restock/maintenance labor (\$500): **net ~\$4,380/month per machine**.
- The viral "\$12,000/month" figure assumes 200 cups/day at full \$2 — achievable at a stadium on event days, but plan around the steadier number.

How To Start

1. **Order one sample sauce-dispensing machine** from a vetted Alibaba supplier via Trade Assurance; demand a working-unit video and food-grade tubing/components.

2. **Form an LLC**, get liability insurance, and secure your local food-vending/health permit (sauce is a food product — confirm refrigeration rules).
3. **Lock a destination-traffic placement** — theme park, stadium, food court, cinema, or family entertainment center — on a flat-rent or 12–18% revenue-share deal.
4. **Source sauce concentrates** (a food co-packer or wholesale condiment supplier) and load 6–10 base flavors that combine well.
5. **Set \$2 pricing on the screen, enable card + Apple Pay**, and design a bold, camera-friendly machine front.
6. **Launch a hashtag and an in-app "name your sauce" gimmick** to fuel user videos.
7. **Run 30 days of data, refine the flavor menu, then reinvest into machine #2 or a sponsor deal.**

Where To Get Customers

Place machines where people come to have fun and share online: theme parks, stadiums, arenas, cinemas, mall food courts, family entertainment centers, and festivals. The dispense is inherently viral, so seed TikTok/Instagram with combo-challenge clips, add a QR "tag us for a free cup," list each location on Google Business, and partner with venue social accounts to feature the machine.

Pro Tips

- **Sell the experience, not the sauce** — lean into the "invent your own flavor" novelty and design the machine to be filmed; every customer video is a free ad.
- **Court a sauce-brand sponsorship early** (Heinz-style) — a featured-flavor deal can cover your machine cost while you keep the per-cup revenue.
- **Chase event-driven venues** (stadiums, theme parks) where crowds spike and people are in spend-for-fun mode; one big event day can match a slow week elsewhere.